

Elizabeth Jameson

In her series, *Reimagined Brain*, artist Elizabeth Jameson creates solar plate etchings that reimagine MRI images of her brain and x-rays of her spinal cord, now saturated with rich colors despite their impairment from multiple sclerosis (MS). MS is a neurological condition that disrupts the transmission of nerve signals from the brain through the spinal cord to the body, causing anomalies. The result is weakened or restricted control over bodily functions. As one MS-person explained: "Imagine feeling weak, in pain or like you have the flu and you struggle just to lift your arms or stand..." The disruption occurs when the body's immune system attacks myelin, a protein and fatty substance that is meant to surround and protect nerve fibers. The loss of myelin causes the body to form scar tissue (called sclerosis) which interrupts electrical impulses to and from the brain...By exposing a light-sensitive printing plate through a black-and-white axial MRI scan of the artist's brain, Jameson etched a plate that she would then print and enhance with brilliant colors of paint, colored pencil, and chalk. We would be remiss, however, if we focused only on the literal and negative impact of scars on her brain, for Jameson's work is also celebratory. Her larger-than-life prints reflect the beauty of a brain in transition as it struggles to survive and the mysteries of adaptation. Intriguing prints capture such diverse visual brain descriptors as "drama and mystery" and "beauty and romance," as well as "chronic illness," and "intrigue." In visually stunning images such as *Valentine I*, colors dance across the surface, disguising the analytical nature of an MRI image of the artist's brain stem, cerebellum, and lateral ventricles. With a shape that resembles the heart, Jameson moves beyond the practical medical reading of the brain scan to expose a "warmth and vulnerability." Although not always visible, MS is widespread with close to one million people affected in the United States and nearly three million worldwide. Its effects can be overtly recognizable or nearly invisible. It can dramatically disrupt walking, moving, or speaking, but it can also lead to less visible symptoms which include slight tremors, exhaustion, stiffness, depression, headaches, cognitive disruption, and bowel and bladder dysfunction. As a result, it can be a frustrating disease for those who seek recognition and understanding. According to the Invisible Disabilities Association, one of the greatest complaints of people living with MS is that others assume they are well if they "look good." Jameson's MS disability is not invisible. In fact, MS has affected her body to the point where it is highly visible with quadriparesis and slowing speech. Yet, it is through her art and presentations that she celebrates her "imperfect body" both inside and out, creating a space for conversation.

—Timothy W. Hiles, *Art, Movement, and Disability: Transcending the Beauty Paradigm*, (New York: Routledge Press, 2026), p. 99-100.